Tariq bhai came and confronted me about how I should be home once the match was over. When I protested, he slapped me – in front of everyone.

I felt so small, embarrassed and angry. Tariq bhai had insulted me by hitting me in public. He also warned me that while he encouraged my playing cricket – he too had played cricket at the first-class level and was, in fact, a very good fast bowler – he didn't approve of the social habits I'd embraced on the side.

I was incensed that he had insulted me in front of everyone. But it was only years later that I realized the importance of what he had done. Not only did I deserve that slap, I was also glad that he gave it to me in public. Had I continued associating with those people, in those heady years of being a teen in central Karachi, I'm sure I would have lost my focus on cricket. Many of the guys I hung out with didn't end up doing too well.

Here's the thing about being young. At that age, you always think you're right and nobody else 'gets it' but you. It's you versus the world. But I've learnt the hard way that our elders are always thinking about the big picture, about the larger issues in life, which you can't see as a youngster who is well-intentioned but too self-involved.

That's what that slap was. As a cricketer, Tariq bhai could have been as legendary as Imran Khan for me. I believed he was *that* good. More importantly, he was also the wall between my father and me, and encouraged and protected my cricketing pursuits from my disapproving father. If he had hurt me, he had done so for a reason.